



G. PRASAD REDDY BJP

Rs 313 crore of assets make him the richest person to be contesting the upcoming polls. The real estate raja is contesting from BTM Layout.

"This is the time to give back to the state what it has given us, and we have the inclination to do so."

with booze, a number of vehicles carting liquor have been seized by election observers. In April this year, a day after BSP candidate and liquor trader Rangaswami filed his nomination from the temple town of Melkote in the Mandya district, his son Mahesh, a Zila Parishad member, was murdered in broad daylight, putting the spotlight on the business of lobbying. Nevertheless, liquor barons like Vijay Mallya and D.K. Adikesavulu continue to exercise influence over political giants across the spectrum.

The forthcoming election is markedly different because of the emergence of new money from real estate, mining, and to some extent, education. Karnataka is home to a large percentage of medical and engineering colleges in the country, most of them owned by politicians. About 20,000 seats in private colleges offering professional courses across the state are called 'management seats', for each of which they charge a capitation fee of about Rs 3 lakh every year. These rich colleges exercise power especially in north and central Karnataka, where there is hardly any profit-making industry. Whether it is Shivakumar, Congress leader C.K. Jaffer Sharief, state Congress President Mallikarjuna Kharge, party Treasurer Shivashankarappa or veteran leader R.L. Jalappa—many politicians are attached to educational institutions. Shivakumar—who is contesting the Kanakapura Assembly seat and is worth Rs 76 crore—is the chairman of the Global Academy of Technology, which hosted an interaction between IT professionals and Congress leader Rahul Gandhi as well as former chief minister S.M. Krishna at the Indian Institute of Science in Bangalore in March. It was a high-level campaign aimed at the infotech votebank.

Another industry that has catapulted its owners to the political stage is mining. The business is so lucrative that family members of JD(S) chief H.D. Deve Gowda have reportedly earned crores from the iron-ore mining trade. With the huge demand for iron ore in China driving the export business, almost all the mining barons of Bellary district have found an influential career in politics. The mining lobby is expected to influence at least 40 seats

in six districts in and around Bellary. BJP's Reddy brothers—Janardhan, an MLC who claimed that former chief minister H.D. Kumaraswamy was involved in a Rs 150-crore mining scam, Somashekhara and Karunkara, who are contesting two Assembly seats from Bellary—have single-handedly crushed the Congress stranglehold on the district. The Reddys not only lend their helicopters to party faithfuls but also liberally contribute to the party's funding.

Other mining barons like Santosh and Anil Lad, who were part of the BJP family, are now contesting on Congress tickets. Anil, 38, one of the youngest mining barons to own a Bell 407 six-seater helicopter, besides some imported cars, is worth Rs 178 crore. It is interesting to see these billionaires change their political colours. Anil, who as a BJP legislator, openly flaunted his closeness to Kumaraswamy, was welcomed into the Congress last month by former state party president and Lingayat leader from Bellary Allum Veerabhadrappe. Soon after, when miscreants burned some of the cars parked outside his bungalow in Bellary, Anil conveniently blamed it on his BJP rival. The Lad brothers' father Heeroji Lad was a Congress MLA from Sandur, home to the Ghorpade rajas of the past.

E. Krishnappa, 50, who produced the superhit Kannada movie *Mungaru Male* (Monsoon Showers) and is also in the real estate business, has been allotted the JD(S) ticket from Yelahanka, close to the new international airport in Devanahalli. The first-timer is worth Rs 44 crore—small change compared to the wealth of the mining barons of Bellary and the real estate kings of Bangalore.

At a time when no party is expected to touch the magic figure of 113, these lobbies will have a strong role to play. If real estate tycoons come to rule the roost in the Karnataka Assembly, one can expect whole new cityscapes. "We are all interested in the development of Karnataka's cities and want to work for the welfare of the community. This floor will help us do that," says Prasad Reddy, confident that the people are ready for their new cash-rich netas, with their Mercs and all. ■

to Bangalore, which is now witnessing a strong pro-Kannada movement.

Jayarama Reddy, the patriarch of the SJR Group, almost got the Congress ticket from Shanthinagar, but it had to be handed over to a Muslim candidate, Nalapad Ahmed Harris, following pressure from the Muslim lobby in the Congress. The party hopes that this large minority community, which accounts for nearly 12 per cent of the state's electorate, will vote for it en bloc.

Not so long ago, Karnataka politics was characterised and monopolised by the liquor lobby, whose hold has slackened after the establishment of the Karnataka State Beverages Corporation in 2003 to plug the leaks in excise revenue from liquor—ending the sale of "seconds" or tax-evaded liquor. While attempts are still being made to buy the votes of thickly populated slums